



On the comeback trail: While losing six months of training might be a near-fatal career blow, Mirabai managed to recover almost entirely.

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severe. That gave some hope that perhaps the injury wasn't nearly as bad as we first thought," says Sharma.

The injury remains a mystery. "At first, Dr. Pardiwala thought that Mira might need surgery, so he got every test done, including multiple MRIs and full-body scans. But no abnormality was detected. Even now, we can't tell what the issue was," says Sharma.

While they couldn't diagnose the

issue, Mirabai was advised rest and to rehabilitate her hip until at least the end of the year. She wasn't allowed to put any strain on her lower body and was only able to do bodyweight training on her upper half.

Mirabai says those five months until the start of 2024 were among the most stressful of her life. "It's a very big thing for a player to miss five months of training, that too when you don't know what the future will be. I didn't know whether my injury would actually get better after five months. But even if it did, in the best-case scenario, I knew that I would be starting from zero when I did restart my training," she says.

She had to call for backup. "I believe a lot in Hanuman ji. I prayed to him a lot in the last five months," she says. Mira also befriended the stray dogs that inhabit the campus at NIS Patiala. She's somewhat of an unofficial caretaker of Whitey, Blackie, Bhoora, and about half-a-dozen other Indie dogs for whom she provides meals and arranges regular shots and vet visits. "They don't care that I'm an Olympic medallist, or that I did badly at the Asian Games, or that I'm dealing with an injury. They are just happy to see me all the time."

Perhaps the greatest help came from her family. "The best thing that happened to me at that time was